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Dawoud Sabu Adeyola

Dawoud Sabu Adeyola has been a positive presence in the music and cultural fabric of Buffalo, NY since the late '60s. His work is reflective of the influences of Charles Mingus and Ahmad Jamal who he cites as significant figures in his development as a musician and human being.

Sabu was interviewed via Zoom on January 30, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very happy to have Dawoud Sabu Adeyola with me this morning. And welcome, sir.

SA: Good morning. How are you?

MR: I'm good. I'm going to introduce you as a bassist, composer, jazz educator, and a well known figure in Buffalo and beyond.

SA: Yeah that's a fair description. Thank you.

MR: All right. I used to live in Buffalo myself for a while, and would go down to the Tralfamadore down those stairs, and I was thinking this morning, did the music scene, the jazz scene, which I know a lot of jazz musicians would pass through Buffalo. Did it make an impression on you when you were in your teenage years?

SA: Oh without a doubt. Yeah. When I grew up here in Buffalo, first of all thanks for having me, I really appreciate this opportunity. I think it's very important. As you know I'm a bit of a historian myself. I've written at least one book about the history of the Colored Musicians Club here in Buffalo, and its parent, Local 533. And there's a new edition that should be forthcoming soon, which is kind of updating, you know, and, you know got a little bit more research materials in it. But yeah, when I grew up in Buffalo, I was born and raised in Buffalo, and yeah, we had quite a scene here in Buffalo, a lot of clubs, a lot of venues. When I was in high school I started visiting the local clubs such as the Pine Grill and the Rebelot and the BonTon. And my very first jazz concert ever that I went to was at Kleinhans Music Hall, which was the Cannonball Adderley Sextet with Nancy Wilson.

MR: Oh no. You just said the magic words.

SA: I think I was a freshman in high school.

MR: People who know me know that my favorite LP is Nancy Wilson and Cannonball Adderley.

SA: Oh, that's a great album. They had just made that album, for Capitol Records, when they came to Kleinhans, and it was a double bill because George Shearing was on the first half, and then Cannonball's quintet was on the second, and with Cannonball, his brother

Nat, Yusef Lateef, Joe Zawinul, one of my very favorite mentors, Sam Jones on bass, and Louis Hayes on drums. So I had a good, you know, it was like my coming out party. That's the first jazz concert I ever went to.

MR: Were you playing the bass at the time?

SA: I was not. At that time I was a piano student.

MR: Well it begs the question, what made you switch to the most important instrument in any combo?

SA: Couple things. For one I had a companion, a growing-up buddy, Juni Booth, which you probably know about, Mr. Booth. He lived a couple of blocks away from me. And we were both playing piano, you know. I was taking formal lessons at the Wurlitzer School of Music, and he was kind of self-taught, also studying with one of Buffalo's local heroes, legends, Billy Gault, pianist. I don't know if you know about Billy Gault, but he recorded with Jackie McLean and was on the staff there at the school in Hartford for a while, I think he lives in Hartford. Billy Gault. Well he was quite a mentor to a lot of musicians including Juni and myself. So anyway Juni and I used to — Juni didn't have a piano and so I did, so we'd be over my house. We used to go through the neighborhood going — wherever we could find a piano we'd go there and we'd just try to play and cut each other up on piano you know. So we wound up in that same high school, East High School, and I had been thinking about the bass, especially you know since I'd met Sam Jones and the bass was always kind of fascinating to me you know. I had my eye on it. And one day I decided to go to the music room at high school and just ask about the bass you know. And the music director, the band director told me, "Oh man, you're one day too late because Juni Booth just came and got the last bass."

MR: He cut you.

SA: He did. I said, man this guy, because he was always a step ahead of me on piano, he was real smart, a real genius kid you know. And I said man he did it again. So I put the bass out of my mind until I wound up in Germany in 1965. I was sent to Germany in the Air Force. I had three years to do and on one period I said what am I going to do in just three years that's not going to make it just a big hole and a gap in my life you know? And so I thought about — well I'm in the land of the violin, maybe I can find a bass over here. So I did, I went around, I started looking around and that's a whole 'nother long story but I happened upon a wonderful bassist who was the principal bassist in the Wurzburg Symphonie. You know he was a soloist. And he was very happy to have me as a student and that's how I got started with the bass.

MR: Were you playing — the piano you were playing at the time, was it classical music or were you learning chords and trying to copy jazz pianists?

SA: I was. I was, you know I was taking classical lessons, like I say my mother started me at the Wurtlitzer School of Music in downtown Buffalo when I was about eight. And they had a deal going that if you bought a new piano you got a year or two of free lessons with the piano. So me and my big sister, we both availed ourself, and we'd go for lessons. And then after that ran out then my mother hired a piano teacher who came by the house you know. And so we were doing all the regular you know piano primer books, but I always had my ear on what was going on at the time, the doo-wop, the soul, and when I got in high school my jazz ear got opened. And so I had a few — and there were a few pianists that I thought I could copy, like Horace Silver and Bobby Timmons, the blues oriented guys. So I started teaching myself how to do that. And so I was kind of doing both at the same time.

MR: I just was reading a book about early rock & roll and the chitlin' circuit and how popular guys like Roy Brown were at the time in the mid-50s. I'm wondering if that music, which was — we used to think of it was pre-rock & roll, or R&B, was that something you listened to? And also I wonder what did your parents like having played in the house? What kind of music?

SA: Well first of all people will ask me what drew me to the bass and I tell them I used to spend, my father sang bass in the choir at the church. And as a little guy I used to stand next to him while he was rolling out these luscious bass notes, you know, in the choir. And so the church was full of family members who were involved in music. My aunt played the organ, directed the choir. I had another uncle who was a baritone soloist. He used to do solo concerts. And my cousins, you know they all play. So we just had a rich musical — and my mother even played. My mother played — she said the whole nine months she was carrying me she was playing in her mother's church. Her mother was an evangelist and so she was playing and directing the choir. And she was wishing that I might be a musician. And later on when I started traveling the globe as a musician she said, "You have to be careful what you pray for."

MR: What you what?

SA: Be careful what you ask for — what you pray for, you know, 'cause it may come back to haunt you. Because I was never at home. But no, yeah, we were very much affect— and see the other thing about those days is that there was only a couple of radio stations and you had race record stores and you had what they called race records — I mean radio stations. And so we were all in the '50s pretty much listening to the same music, you know, the popular music of the time you know. We knew as much about the black R&B artisans as we did about the white ones you know. Because you'd get a little bit of both. They'd mix it up a lot. You know Benny & the Jets and James Brown and the Cadillacs and all these old people. So we grew up on doo-wop basically. Which is basically various

forms of blues. And so I guess we started out imitating those sounds and those chords on the piano, which is a lot of repetition. [scats] So we kind of taught ourselves how to — nobody ever really taught us how to do that, we kind of figured it out.

MR: Did you get the impression, once you started playing the bass, I'm going to guess that your listening habits started centering more on that part of the music and you start to learn patterns and hearing them before you even went to play them.

SA: Yes. Yeah absolutely. I had — when I was in Germany, when I first started in Germany I had a bunch of records. We had what they call a BX or base exchange that had a lot of records. It had a nice record selection. And so I wound up with a couple of hundred albums in my room in the barracks you know. And another early experience that affected my whole life was New Year's Eve 1963. I was going into my — well actually I was in the middle of my senior year. Because I graduated in June of '64. So yeah it was my junior year. '63 was coming in and Miles Davis came to — the Miles Davis Quintet came to downtown Buffalo. I think it was the Town Casino. And I had been listening to the records, those records he made on Prestige, before he got to Columbia you know, he made a bunch of records just to get out of the contract. "Relaxin' with the Miles Davis Quartet," "Workin' with the Miles Davis Quintet," "Cookin' with the Miles Davis Quartet," and even beyond — even before that when he was making records with Bird and "Birth of the Cool." But I was really into what they call hard bop with most of those groups that had John Coltrane, Paul Chambers, Red Garland. So anyway, when I heard he was coming to the Town Casino of course I showed up. And — but I was disappointed when I got there because I was looking for Paul Chambers, Wynton Kelly or Red Garland. And maybe Coltrane or somebody like that. He shown in with these new guys you know, that I had never heard of before. These young guys. Tony Williams, you know, Ron Carter, Herbie Hancock.

MR: He couldn't get anybody good, huh?

SA: And George Coleman. And I'm like oh man, that Miles, come on man, what are you doing man, who are these guys? Not realizing that this is the group that going to be called the second great quintet. And so that's what I remember about that concert, that I was very disappointed at first, but then when I heard them I said, well yeah, this might be okay — he had just put that group together — and the other thing I remember about that concert is how small the audience was. I was like where's everybody? I mean what? This is Miles Davis. I mean even a kid of sixteen, you know, in those days and I'm saying this place is supposed to be packed. But at least the night I went he think I had about two or three nights, and the night I went there was almost no one there.

MR: Do you recall, beyond the music, noticing how they operate on stage? Visual cues, just watching the bass player interact with the drummer, was any of that apparent to you?

SA: Oh yeah, yeah. I was very — especially I mean the first concert, I mean with the Cannonball thing and George Shearing, — Kleinhans — you know I'm sitting way in the back and you know I couldn't really focus in on the interactions and that, but at the Town Casino I'm sitting right almost underneath him you know and I could see. And then of course everybody had an eye on Miles 'cause he had a reputation for doing different stuff, turning his back or leaving the stage, you know and that kind of stuff you know. And so I'm really watching him. And this time I had no idea about music as a profession or bass or anything like that, I'm just really somebody who fell in love with the music and was kind of trying to follow it you know. But they were definitely communicating with each other, but again, not to the extent that they got to later on you know I mean because I think he announced that this group was brand new, only, not even six months old. And so they were still kind of feeling each other out, you know what I mean? To play with each other. And I think that was in the time with Tony, they had to paint a moustache on him to try to get him in because he was only — he was under-aged. You know.

MR: He wasn't that much older than you at the time, was he?

SA: One year. One year. I think he was born in '46, I was born in ' 47.

MR: Do you remember the first time you got paid to play your bass?

SA: Yes, yes. I do. It was from a man named Elvin Shepherd. You know about Elvin Shepherd?

MR: I see his name on your promo material.

SA: Elvin Shepherd was a great musician. He was Grover Washington's teacher. And when Grover went, if you ever see any interviews about Grover Washington and they ask him about, like you asked me about my background, he always goes on and on and on about how great Elvin Shepherd was. And Elvin Shepherd was a member of the Local 533, the black musicians union, which is a whole 'nother story. I was so blessed to be a part of that. I joined that union six months before it was dissolved. You know? I mean the union, the white union and the black union were merged by mandate. It was mandated. The merger — there were about almost 20 cities and Buffalo that had segregated unions. And in 1953 they started merging, and Los Angeles was the first one. Benny Carter was a big part of that. Benny Carter, because of his stature, I mean he's the king you know, and he got involved with the union. I mean you had to be in the union but being in L.A. with all the entertainment movies and stuff and he led, he said, even then he was saying man it's crazy, why should we have two unions? I mean the black union and the white? This is crazy. So he led the move to integrate the unions out there and '53 and '54 that was the first one. Gradually they all started merging, especially after the Civil Rights Act of '65, which said that segregation is illegal. Buffalo was the very last one to do it. You know?

MR: Did you notice a positive or negative circumstances that followed that merging of the union?

SA: I saw both actually. I mean in the long run it was good because segregation in any form, you know based on race, gender, religion, is always — I mean even as a kid I was raised in the African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church and I used to wonder why — I mean it was segregated you know what I mean? If you — if a white person came to serve, to worship and sat down, people would be wondering oh, who is that? What's he doing here? You know. I mean this was in the '50s you know, up north in Buffalo. And so we had this segreg — as Malcolm X said one time, he said, "the most segregated time in America is 12 o'clock on Sundays" you know. So anyway how did I go there? You were asking about the after-effect. In the long run it was positive because you know it broke down this law that was actually — it was sanctions you know, just like segregation and even slavery was sanctioned by the government and by the Constitution and this thing went on into labor unions so in that sense it was good that it was no longer the law of the land, because it was actually illegal. But in terms of the actual impact on the ground, black musicians suffered you know, because even though the union was formed on it because they were refusing to listen to the white union at Local 43 at that time you know. And so it was formed out of necessity because if you wanted to work you had to have a union card. And so one of the guys, you know, one of the white musicians came over and he was against it. He didn't agree with it. And he sat down with some of these blacks and he said, "Listen you guys, if they won't let you join you probably should form your own union." And he knew how to do it, you know? So he helped form Local 533. And he told them you have to form it — at that time there were two kinds of black unions. One was called a subsidiary union, which was under the control and under the supervision of the white union. They had almost no authority. They had a union but to do anything they had to go over there to the office over there and when they had the national conventions they weren't invited, they couldn't vote, you know what I mean? But then you had independent autonomous unions which this guys said you've got to get that autonomous part. "You guys would be autonomous. You've got to vote, you're a legitimate union just like any other." So that's what Local 533 was. But they had developed a lot of things that even 43 didn't have. They had a credit union, they had death benefits, you know they had I mean a credit union, I mean, that's a bank. I mean they set this up way back in the '20s and '30s. They were pretty smart. They had a bank account that was about triple the size of the other one you know. So, and they had a building, all right? Which still, as you know, is there. So we lost everything pretty much in the merger because you know the larger union kind of swallows up the assets of the small one. They lost everything but the

building. And the reason they didn't lose the building is because it was incorporated away from the union. It has its own incorporation status.

MR: I see. That's a great story.

SA: And it was a great thing because they said listen this segregation thing is not going to last and when they merge the other union is going to come in and they're going to swallow up all your assets, including your real estate. And so when it came the president of the old union, they actually came over and asked for the key you know. Yeah. He said, "Well we'll take the key, we'll take the building now." So the president, his name was Perry Gray, he was a shrewd guy you know. He said, "You want the key, okay, I'll tell you what. Come upstairs I'll buy you a drink." So they're sitting there, "So what are you having?" So he gave him — "Give him what he wants" you know. So he was sitting there drinking and he said, "Now, about this key, look up over the bar there, you see that Certificate of Incorporation? It's called the Musicians Club Incorporated, it has nothing to do with the union. Sorry sir, no key."

MR: "Enjoy your drink."

SA: Enjoy. Right, right. So that's a story — the old guys love to tell that story. Yeah, man, the guy came over here to ask for the key, can you imagine that?

MR: I want to go back to your first gig because I want to see if you made as much as I did on my first gig.

SA: 25 bucks.

MR: Ooh. Not bad for a first gig.

SA: What'd you make?

MR: Back then.

SA: What'd you make?

MR: I made 4.

SA: Whoa, whoa. What year was that? Well no, no you know what? You know I take it back. I'll tell you that wasn't the first time I got paid. The first time I got paid was when I was in high school when I was still playing piano. You know — you've heard of Joe Ford, right? Saxophone?

MR: Yeah.

SA: Okay. Joe Ford is another one. He and I had our very first gigs together and he was playing saxophone then. It was a trio. It was saxophone, piano, and conga. And the conga player, his name was Reggie McQuella. He was the leader of the band. He organized this whole thing. And it was at the YMCA and it was a dance. And people were actually dancing you know. I think we made about 10 or 12 dollars apiece on that gig. Yeah.

MR: That's a lot of pressure on the piano player with no bass and, you know, carrying the rhythm.

SA: Yeah. So I must have been doing something okay you know. So we had a couple of little gigs like that.

MR: Let me jump ahead a little bit. When I look at your list of people that you've collaborated with, you're going everywhere from Big Joe Turner to Ahmad Jamal to Dexter Gordon and on. I'm trying to form a question about from a bass player standpoint do you feel you adjust your playing to the circumstance? I mean it almost sounds like oh of course yes, but people write about like Miles is quoted as saying that Ahmad Jamal taught him about using space. When you play with these variety of musicians how do you pick up on what you should be doing?

SA: Well the first thing, like I tell my students in the university, the first thing you have to do as a bassist or a rhythm section player, I think it's true you know, chord players — pianists, guitarists, drummers, but especially the bass player. You have to be a really, a good listener you know. But then you have to have a repertoire. I mean you have to know a lot of songs, a lot of tunes, a lot of patterns you know. I was fortunate when I first started playing around Buffalo there was a piano player named JAMAN. Jimmy Manuel. I was a part of his trio. And he had a — his repertoire book was like huge, you know what I mean? He passed on now. I should have done it but I've got a mind to ask — call his widow and ask what happened to that book he had, because he had a bunch of tunes in there. And so he would try to play all those tunes you know. And he had charts. So I learned a lot of standards and at that time the bossa nova was kind of getting big so he was on top of that. He had a lot of those, you know, songs from Carlos Jobim and whatnot. So that's the first thing is to be familiar with the literature of music. And the second thing is you have to really listen because everybody's different. As you mentioned, and Miles observed, Ahmad at the beginning he was known for using space, but when I got with him he was filling up those spaces more. You know and he was playing like really — and so he was really — some of the critics said that they attributed — that maybe I had a little influence on him because I was kind of a heavier, you know, I had like a heavier touch. But if you listen to those, like what we did in France with Gary Burton is really the way he played "Manha de Carnaval" and all those — it was really hot and it was really a lot. And with Peyton Crossley on drums who — you know Peyton Crossley and Tony Williams had the same teacher in Boston, Alan Dawson. And Roy Haynes is from Boston too. So there's a certain thing about those Boston drummers that they brought with them to New York. But yeah, no, that's a long answer but basically you have to be a really good listener because everybody plays differently. For instance when I played with Joe Turner, if I remember correctly, he's known as a blues player, right? He did blues all night and everything was in the key of C. You know? Everything. But — and he brought his own piano player. But it didn't sound like it, it was all different

you know. Same thing with Mose. On the other hand Mose Allison was known as a blues guy but he played very little traditional — I mean it always had the blues feeling, a heavy blues feeling, which really was remarkable, you know, especially for a white musician. I think he's from Mississippi or somewhere like that. But he had this real nice, and he was an excellent pianist too actually. All of his music, it had chord changes. It had charts. When you listened to it, it sounded oh yeah he's playing his blues, but there were always different chord changes in it. You know? So that's the third thing. The first thing is you've got to know a lot, you know you have to be familiar with the literature and you have to be able to listen. Then you also have to be able to read music because a lot of times these guys they come in and there's not — very little rehearsal. Like with Dexter we had one rehearsal. And at that time he had done that recording with Donald Byrd and what's her name, it was a Donald Byrd composition — I can't think of the name of it. But anyway it's a little different. The form was really different you know. And so he said, "Yeah, you know sometimes people ask for this so we tried it a little bit." At that time Virgil Day was the drummer and John Weiss was the piano player. And we looked at it a little bit and just said, "Ah na, it's too hard, we won't do it." So in the middle of the set, we were at the Tralf downstairs, that you mentioned. In the middle of the set, Donald Byrd had been playing in town. I think he did a concert at one of the universities for Buff State. So he walks into the club. He heard Dexter was there so he walks into the club. So people see him and they immediately start requesting this song that we decided we weren't going to do. And Dexter says — he had this deep voice — "Hey people, they want us to play Donald's tune you know, what do you think?" And I said "Well you know, we'll follow you man." So it came out all right. "One Flight Up."

MR: "One Flight Up." That's right.

SA: Do you remember that one? Yeah. It's got a strange form to it you know. It's a long form to it too.

MR: Did any of these artists ever tell you to stop doing something? Or to suggest that why don't you play this this way. Give you some instruction?

SA: The only one was — I think it was Ahmad. Because he — and he didn't do it that much. You know he had a different way of — he didn't play songs the way other people did. He always altered the changes, he always, you know used substitutions. And his substitutions were his own and so you had to learn that from him. You had to learn them. And a lot of times I would hear them, sometimes if I didn't he would you know — and see he didn't do a lot of verbalization in terms of do this, do that, he would just — if he wanted a certain note in the bass he would just hit it. He would just bang-bang-bang-bang — I'd say okay, you got it. And so, and then it went into your permanent memory because — we rehearsed a lot but we didn't do a lot of rehearsing. So having an intuition for it and

being flexible — I remember one time we were — I was working with Abbey Lincoln at the Village Vanguard. And we already had been playing around, the band sounded pretty good. But on the first set of the Village Vanguard we were — she felt like anyway — like the band was a little tight, you know, a little edgy. So she turns around after the first two songs and she says — and the people could hear it too 'cause the mic was on. She says, "Listen, don't worry because this is The Vanguard, this is the easiest place to play in the world. The people love us, you know? Just relax and play." And after that — I always remember that she says, "Na, don't worry, we're cool." And that was — I think that was my favorite job, working with that lady. They call her the "Golden Lady."

MR: I have a quote here from Mr. Al Tinney. And I got to interview him back in 2002 and he was talking about a trio that you were playing at a club called Fanny's I guess.

SA: Yes.

MR: And he described how you guys worked together and he said, and then his quote was: "Well it didn't take us long to do this because I have two exceptionally fine musicians. The drummer is Louie Marino and the bass player is Sabu Adeyola. He's wanted all over town by the right people."

SA: He's so kind. He's my second father you know. Yeah you know what? He actually told my father that. He says, 'cause both of my parents were alive at the time. And sometimes I'd take him by the house you know, because they loved him too. Actually Fanny's was right around the corner from where my parents used to live you know. And so one time we're sitting there at the kitchen table having coffee and he tells my dad, he says, "Oh by the way I've adopted your son, is that all right? Is that okay with you?" He said, "I've adopted him as a son." 'Cause they were around the same age. I mean my father was born in 1920 and Al was born in 1921. And so he says, "Is that all right Mr. Lewis?" And he said, "Oh yeah, no sure man, no problem man." So that's how close we were.

MR: That's great. What a feeling that was to talk to someone who had been in the original production of — you know with George Gershwin of "Porgy & Bess." Like that just really blew my mind.

SA: Yeah I mean that's cool, but to me his association with Charlie Parker man. You know? That Bird actually mentioned him in a couple of books, like Ross Russell's *Bird Lives*. When Bird actually says that the reason that he — when he visited New York with Jay McShann back in the early '40s, and he decided to stay in New York because he went to a jam session at Monroe's and he heard a new form of music being played under the leadership of a pianist named Allen Tinney. And that made him want to stay in New York and learn more about this music. I'm like wow, that's some shit there man. Wow, Bird said that? So and see we didn't know, when we started the Buffalo Jazz Ensemble in 1975, I knew Al but I didn't know all that about him. And somebody came in to a

rehearsal one day, 'cause we used to rehearse four or five days a week. We were like on the city payroll and did concerts all the time. Somebody came in and said, "Al, your name is in this book, this Charlie Parker book and Bird's talking about you man, talking about how great you were and how he learned from you. And the people said, "Aw, no way man." The guy brought the book in and said, "Look. There's your man you know." So everybody was kind of really in awe. So somebody was saying, one of the young guys was saying, "Oh man that's history, that's in the past." And somebody else said, "No, no, no, no bebop is forever. Bebop is not going anywhere." Charlie Parker's still the GOAT man. He's still the GOAT. He's got every — between him and Coltrane. And Coltrane, there's a picture of Coltrane, I don't know if you ever saw this picture. Charlie Parker is playing. It's a big band, right? Somebody's big band, Bird is in the mic and Coltrane is sitting up in front, right? He's on the edge of his seat like this here. He's got a cigarette in his hand, and the ash is about two inches long and getting ready to fall. He's just totally mesmerized. He said, "I can't believe what this guy's doing" but he was going to burn his finger.

MR: Oh that's a great image.

SA: Yeah. It is. I've got to find that picture man. I mean his mouth is open, you know like that.

MR: Let me see if I can put this into a question. Amongst your things you've written or people writing about you, talk about music as a spiritual force and connecting to your African ancestry. I have a couple of questions. First of all was this urge to do that, was it a family thing? Were your parents and your grandparents interested in their ancestry or was this something you found on your own?

SA: That's an interesting question because it is a lot of stuff in there. My mom was very much the educator. And she was a librarian. And she was somebody who had to drop out of high school as a teenager because she was ill. She had rheumatic heart and so she couldn't finish high school. Then she got married and there were five of us. But she used to always say — she got married at 17 I think and she had five kids. I'm the second oldest. And she used to always tell us, "You got to do good in school because as soon as you guys get up to some age or some size I'm going to go back to school and I'm going to finish my education." So we said, "Okay, Mom." "So don't bring no bad report cards in here." So we had to do good in school, right? When my baby sister was about to graduate from high school and go on to college, Mom went back to school and she got her —at that time they didn't have — they had what they call a High School Equivalency. Now they call it something else, I forget what they call it.

MR: G.E.D. — something like that.

SA: Yeah, G.E.D. Before G.E.D. they had what they call High School Equivalency. She got that, and then there was this college program called SEEK which was a state program. She got in that, she got a bachelors, you know, in education. And we said, "Okay Mom proved a point." Next thing we know she's in grad school. She wound up with a masters in Library Science and wound up working for the Erie County Library System until she was about — well her health prevented her from working past I think 64, 65. But while she was a librarian, she did a lot of stuff for history. For instance she's the one who started Martin Luther King day before it was a national holiday she started a program in her little library. She called me up and said, "Listen I think it's a shame that every January comes and nobody —" because she was a big birthday — she celebrated everybody's birthday. She said, "I think it's bad that January 15 comes around and nobody says anything about Doctor King so I'm going to have a little program here in the library, you come down and bring the boys in the band, I'm going to cook some chicken wings" and so we started doing that. And every year it got bigger and bigger and now it's in the — I think it's in the Kleinhans Music Hall now, it's this huge thing you know. And she was very much interested in the Underground Railroad and stuff like that. You know she was from Georgia and remembers coming up to Buffalo on the segregated train with her mom when she was about six. So yeah, it was a kind of DNA you know, it was kind of in the blood. But as far as me personally coming up I loved the music but I thought it was tragic how many of our great musicians like Bird, like Lee Morgan and Hank Mobley and so many others man, you know Bud Powell, that had tragic life circumstances you know. And a lot of times — Fats Waller — and they died young and a lot of it had to do with their lifestyles. You know? It had to do with alcohol, it had to do with drugs. Billie Holiday, you know, Bessie Smith, so many sad stories. But then I noticed that there was another group of musicians who seemed to not have those specific problems, and they were the ones who were more spiritually oriented. You know they were — most of them were Muslim but they could be like Benny Golson was a Jehovah's Witness I think.

MR: And Dizzy.

SA: Dizzy was Bahai.

MR: Yeah.

SA: But you know I did a research project one time on Islam and bebop musicians but when I heard from a couple of those guys is that they used to all hang out in a certain mosque in Harlem. You know Monk, Rollins, even the ones who weren't — a lot of them became Muslim outwardly and changed their names like Yusef Lateef, Ahmad Jamal you know, Sadik Hakin, the piano player. But then there were others people didn't know like McCoy Tyner was Muslim, Art Blakey, Dakota Staton you know, Lynn Hope, the great

saxophone player. Even Kenny Clarke. Kenny Clarke when his book, his autobiography came out it had Kenny Clarke and then his Muslim name underneath it, I think it was Ali, something like that. And they tend to have a better grip on life. A lot of times they had families and they kind of avoided pitfalls. And so with me coming from a pretty much traditional home you know going to church at least once or twice a week, having ministers in the family and whatnot. All right? You know otherwise I could have been you know trying to turned to vice. I said no, no if you become a musician you've got to use drugs or you've got to be an alcoholic. That's the norm. But there was this other group, you know that wasn't about that you know. So that was — even when the John Coltrane Quartet came to the Royal Arms at Buffalo when I was in high school. And John at that time was — he was clean but his years of abuse had pretty much did his liver in and he only had a couple more years to live. But Jimmy Garrison and Elvin Jones, you know, were obviously intoxicated you know, and McCoy Tyner would just sit over by himself sipping on water or soda pop or something like that. And sometimes Yusef Lateef, when he came here, because I used to watch these guys. Yusef Lateef would come, sometimes he wouldn't even leave the bandstand. On break they'd bring him coffee or whatever. He wouldn't even leave the bandstand. He'd go, "I'm not even going down there." So I said yeah, this is — I related to that. I met Yusef Lateef one time when I was a serviceman in Germany, I used to on my breaks sometimes I would just go to different cities and visit you know. And I went to Hamburg one time and Yusef was playing in Hamburg and I got a chance to sit and talk with him for a long time. And he told me about how you know his spirituality, how his religious, how his faith had kept him away from certain things that destroyed other musicians. And he actually gave me some books to read. So yeah, that was a big — it's interesting you should ask because recently I saw an interview like this one, Alice Coltrane did an interview with Branford Marsalis. Have you seen that one?

MR: No.

SA: Yeah, look it up. It's online. It just came out I think. It's really interesting when he asked her about it. And you know Alice is very spiritual you know, very much into the culture. And so was John of course, obviously, everybody knows. But I think Alice had some influence on him or it was probably mutual, that the music is more than just music. In fact in my memoir, which I hope to finish up hopefully by next year. I call it "It's More Than Only Music" you know? More than only music you know. And that music is connections. Connection to the past. Musicians are like recorders you know, we're like recorders or reporters of what's going on in society, what's going on at the time. And especially in the African-American experience, music was one of the few things that we were allowed to preserve something. Because we weren't supposed to read or write or do

any of the literary things and so we do a careful analysis of the musical history whether it be blues, whether it be folk, or gospel or church music or whatnot, we can get a good idea of what was going on in terms of civil rights, in terms of human rights and human suffering and degradation. You can hear the cries in the music. And so that's why I really think that the Lord Almighty gave us the blues, which seems it's not going to ever go away you know and it has many forms. I mean almost all American music forms have some form of blues connection, whether it be jazz, country, rap, whatever they call it, the blues is just there you know.

MR: You made me think of Joe Williams performed here and he introduced one song and he said, "Blues frees the spirit."

SA: Yeah, yeah. It does, it does. And it really comes out of the old spirituals when people were singing and hopes for and prayers for a better day, better conditions. I saw a heart wrenching interview, I mean sometimes stuff just pops up on YouTube and I say, "Oh I've just got to hear this," something popped up the other day, somebody interviewed Nina Simone after she had left the States and went to France I think when she came back and they were interviewing her. And they asked her, you know, "Why did you leave?" And she says, "I left because I didn't like this country. I didn't like the way they were treating me. I didn't like the way they were treating my people you know. And I came back because I thought things might be different you know, and she just really bared her soul and went on in this interview, went on about — I had to stop watching it. I'll get back to it now because you know, the stories she's telling is like so many other musicians who went overseas and then having lived overseas I had a chance to, I know when I was in Berlin one time I ran into Carmell Jones and Leo Wright. And they were saying, "Oh no, we ain't never going back there, man, no we like it just fine here, you know Berlin is all right." When I toured Italy with Abbey Lincoln, which that was an amazing band because Mal Waldron was the piano player you know, and Mal and I got pretty tight you know because he found out I could play chess and he loved to play chess you know so in addition to the music we — if we weren't playing music we were playing chess you know. And so he said the same thing, "Na, na, na I'm not going back there." And Art Farmer lived overseas for a while, Idris Muhammad, and even the old guys, Louis Armstrong, Coleman Hawkins, you know because you know things are just different. Musicians and artists are given another level of respect. You don't make a ton of money but you get treated like somebody special which is something I think all artists need to do to encourage them to continue in their art.

MR: I want to ask you about a video I saw, it was a sextet I think of you at the Buffalo History Museum. I believe you were playing a composition called "Joy." Does that ring a bell?

SA: "Joy?" At the Buffalo History Museum.

MR: Yeah.

SA: Oh no, no, no, no you know what? The lady who recorded it, her name was Joy.

MR: Okay. I thought that might be something. Yeah, there was a fellow with a curved soprano and a trumpet.

SA: Yeah.

MR: So I have a couple of observations. You had a sort of a lengthy bass intro to the tune, and two people came to mind while you were playing. One was Henry Grimes and the other is Buster Williams.

SA: Yeah. Two of my guys, yeah, two of my guys. Buster Williams and I go back to the '70s you know when he was playing with Herbie and Mwandishi. And those guys used to come to Buffalo. And we kind of — we met each other you know — I never got a chance to really collaborate with him but I always admired, he's a great bass player. Henry Grimes I actually got a chance to play with. He came to Buffalo a couple of years before he passed, and he came to the club and he was playing — you know he played violin too —

MR: Yes.

SA: So he wanted to play the violin and he asked me to play bass. And so there's a couple of pictures of us playing together you know, but you know bass players I just — they're in my soul. Richard Davis was my — coming up Richard Davis and Paul Chambers were my main guys you know. And then of course I got a chance to study with Ron Carter you know, and my famous, what I'm most known for is the time I spent with Charles Mingus you know which the funny thing about that though, with Mingus it was more about composition than bass playing. I played bass with him. That's the way he taught, his composition class at the university, he'd just come in, he'd give me the music, he'd sit down and he'd play the tune on the piano and I'd follow along. And then I wound up playing in his band for one night so I guess he figured I'd learned the music pretty good you know. And when the book came out, *Beneath the Underdog*, the publisher wanted to have a book release party and they wanted the band to play but they also wanted him to be around to autograph books and talk to people. And so he brings me down from Buffalo to play with the Charles Mingus Sextet and he didn't ask me was I available or would I like to do it, he just tells me at the end of one class, "Oh you've got to call Sue 'cause she makes your arrangements." I said, "For what?" He said, "You're coming to New York" on so-and-so day, "I didn't tell you?" I said, "No you did not." I said, "For what?" He said, "You've got to play with my band." I said, "Come on Charles, me? Stand in your footsteps? Play your bass and whatnot?" And so it happened and I was 24 years old at the time.

MR: Oh man. Did any of his — he would stand up for himself is one way to put it. He didn't suffer fools gladly. Did you learn and observe that behavior and say this could be part of the way I need to operate on occasion?

SA: Absolutely. I was — see when we were coming up in the '60s, especially when I was in high school as young artists, as young black men we were ready, there was a lot of that going on you know what I mean? A lot of assassinations were going on, there was a lot of protests and a lot of stuff was happening. And so we were looking for the right role models, you know, to want to be a part of this you know. And so we had people, Mingus was one of our main guys because he was a rebel, you know he wasn't just accepting the status quo you know. He was demanding his rights and fussing with the industry. He made us aware of the fact of the injustice of the business aspect of music, as music is, like I says, it's more than only music, that music is also business, music has also a claim to dignity and a claim to some things that really traditionally have been denied. And if you were coming up in this experience, if you weren't an athlete or some kind of an artist or somebody who could do something special, then you might not, you know you may be suffering all your life you know. And so Mingus broke with that. And I know one time we had an after-school — this is long before I thought I might play bass — we had an after-school club in high school, a jazz club where we would bring — we had a trumpet player, he was a biology teacher but he also was a pretty good trumpet player. Italian guy named Sam Molé. And he organized this jazz club 'cause he saw us walking around with our albums and he knew we loved music. "Why don't you guys come to my classroom — the science lab — it had the big black thing in front with the faucet. That was a lab. And so he would set up a turntable, or at that time he had the record players that the speaker was in the top, you just flipped it off. And we'd bring records in and play them and then we would discuss and analyze the music. And so one time somebody brought in "Mingus Dynasty." And I mean before we played the music you know we had a big discussion about the cover 'cause Charles in on there with all this Chinese regalia on and stuff you know. And one guy said, "Man who does this guy think he is, man?" And somebody else said, "That's who he thinks he is." Just the way he's dressed you know. So that's where I got the idea of how you present yourself in terms of how you dress on stage and whatnot, it sends a big message out. And then Rufus Harley used to come to Buff — you ever heard of Rufus Harley?

MR: Oh he's the bagpipe player?

SA: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. Rufus would come to town and he'd come up, I mean he'd come onstage with a whole kilt, a Scottish kilt and the whole, everything. Like a Scotsman. And he had a long history about Africans in Scotland and how bagpipe is originally our instrument you know. I mean that one record he made called "Bagpipe Blues," you

know? So we have people like this you know. Of course Monk, you know Monk is doing it only the way he could do it, you know he always had a hat on or a goofy something covering his head. You know he's dancing around the to the music on the stage. Freedom of expression is what we learned from these guys, that you can — in this music you can be free as you want to be or as you need to be. You don't have to conform because your music and your art and the gift, your God-given gift is enough to qualify you to make a statement that you think needs to be made. And so Mingus, even long before — I had no idea that one day I would be called his protégé or be associated with him or play in the band. His band? I mean if you told me that in high school I would have told you no way, you're crazy man. You know? But this stuff happened to me, you know? And I'm just thankful — and a lot of my students ask, they say how did you do all that stuff? I said a lot of it is just being in the right place at the right time. You can't plan it. That's why hang time among musicians, as you know, hang time is just as important as playing time. You know? Sometimes you've got to be, you've got to just be there to be noticed. I was playing in San Francisco one time at the Keystone Korner with Ahmad again, and on the break Stan Getz comes up to me there. And he says, "Hey man," — and what I love about musicians is that they always have camaraderie. They come up and they have no [inaudible]. So he comes up to me and he says, "Hey Sabu, I see you here." And he said, "Hey man, let me ask you a question." I say, "Yeah, what?" He said, "How do you keep up with that guy? He's all over the place." You know? And he knows that a lot of the stuff we're doing is not rehearsed you know, it's just intuitive. He says, "How do you do that?" I told him I said, "Stan I just learned how to listen well." You know?

MR: Who was he referring to? How do you keep up —

SA: Stan Getz. He's talking about Ahmad.

MR: Okay.

SA: I was playing with Ahmad Jamal. Yeah. And of course in Keystone Korner in those days, that was the spot. The audience, just like the Vanguard and Sweet Basil's and places in New York, the audience is mainly musicians you know. I mean not just — I mean you've got Stan Getz here and Joe Henderson's over there, and Woody Shaw is in the building, Mulgrew Miller is over there. You know. And there's just all these great musicians man, they're looking at you like yeah what are you going to do. But like I say, being in certain places in certain venues will get you opportunities that you might not get if you just stayed home or you just went to your own gigs and then you don't socialize with the musicians, you don't hang out with them.

MR: Yeah.

SA: Thanks — I think that was my composition I was playing, "Oasis for Jalilah" where I took an extended solo in the front of it.

MR: Yes. And it made me wonder what you hope listeners get from your music? I don't know if I could have phrased that in a better way, but do you hope — I think you know what I mean.

SA: Yeah. I think my answer would be similar to what John Coltrane was asked a similar question one time and I loved his answer. He said, "I hope to make people realize that we live in a big beautiful universe. We are only a tiny part of a beautiful universe and that I will hope that my listeners realize that there is meaning to life. Life has meaning and certainly life does have meaning, and that this meaning can be expressed through music. And something like that he said. And I always thought that that was really the short but very appropriate answer, that music is a reflection of life, and life has a very deep meaning and we should never take it for granted. And that the musician, especially the spiritually attuned musician is always trying to connect. You know? Like Albert Ayler said, music is the healing force of the universe. I love that quote from him too. And that the musicians that I love the most are the ones that are not afraid, you know, to stretch the boundaries and even break the rules. Like I tell students all the time, you have to learn the rules so you know how to break them.

MR: That's a good one. I've heard people say and write about free jazz, because you mentioned Albert Ayler — a lot of times it seems like why are these musicians so angry. And I once asked Rashied Ali about that and he said it was more about just a reflection of the times. I wonder if you have a thought about that?

SA: Yeah I think anger is a misinterpretation. Like one time they asked Archie Shepp was he angry. This was back in the heyday when Archie was pretty big in the '60s. And he said, he said, "Why are musicians so — are you guys angry?" He said, "No we're not angry, we're enraged." You know? We're enraged about the conditions, about the history, about the way we've been treated, about — Dexter Gordon talks about, in his biography he talks about how when he was in the Army, right — a Lieutenant or maybe a Sergeant or a superior officer came in to his space, right? And he had a picture of his wife there on the dresser, by the bed. And the guy said something — he didn't say exactly what he said, but he said something disrespectful, because the wife was lighter skinned and very beautiful. And he asked him who is that. He said, "That's my wife." And he said something that Dexter didn't like and so he decked him.

MR: He what?

SA: He decked him. He hit him.

MR: Oh.

SA: He hit him, punched him out. And you know Dexter's about 6 feet 7, you know a big guy. Anyway so he hit this guy because he said something about his wife or her complexion or something like what are you doing with a white woman. Something like

that. And so he hit the guy and then he went on to jail, to the brig or what they call it in the Army you know. And then he stayed there — he had a bad, like Lester Young, he had a bad military experience you know. They said Lester was never the same after he came out of the Army. And you could hear it in the records the way he was playing with Count Basie and whatnot, before he got drafted and — his records afterwards they were still good but they weren't on the same level. But Dexter went through that and what he said in terms of anger he said that it seems to him that America should be grateful, especially to the bebop musicians, most of whom were veterans — as he said, it seems like the veterans of World War II are actually the ones who created bebop you know. And a lot of them were vets, including Al Tinney, Dexter, Elvin Jones, a lot of times they didn't make a big deal about it. You might not have known it, you know, but they actually went and put their lives on the line for this country and then to come back and be treated in such a way, it's upsetting. It's upsetting. But when it comes to artists I think more so than anger it's about expressing the desire or a need or a real, you know, a real belief that things can be better. That we can be better but we all have to do something. You know we can't just sit back and just tsk tsk, and just say oh too bad. But we have to all be active participants in trying to make things better. And so like a lot of people were upset when John Coltrane kind of went into outer space towards the end you know, breaking the rules and playing against tradition and playing different. Even Miles, even Miles did it a different way, but I think all of the artists they were trying to say to us that you know we can't be stagnant. We can't be complacent. That we have to keep moving the boundaries. We have to keep expanding our horizons. That's our job as artists you know. If we're not doing that — and most of the artists, even European artists like Picasso and Michelangelo — all great artists, they were all involved in trying to expand the boundaries, you know, and get people to see things in another way, hopefully a better way.

MR: Well said. And all the more important in these particular times.

SA: Absolutely. Yeah. We're seeing a retrogression now you know. You see a lot of people now talking about — just throwing up their hands and moving to another country. Because things are that bad. I mean you've got people trying to re-make this whole democratic experience you know, in their own image, which is not progressive, it's digressive. You know? And it seems like they want to go back to a time in history which, you know, most Americans are embarrassed about. You know, most Americans are wishing we never had slavery. Wishing that we never had, that it didn't take centuries for women to be able to get to vote, you know, and that they shouldn't — most of us if we could go back and re-write history we'd try to write in the true image of what the democratic ideal says it's supposed to be, which is freedom, justice and equality for all — equal opportunities — and we know that that has not been the case. But it also shows us

the benefit of organization. These people now that are so well organized, I mean taking over, taking us back there, are well organized you know. Well organized. And the musicians have realized a long time ago, like I remember one time the — in Chicago, what's the name of the group?

MR: The AACM.

SA: The AACM. And what's the trumpet player, he used to wear the doctor's coat all the time?

MR: Lester Bowie.

SA: Lester Bowie. Lester Bowie was interviewed one time and he said, "Yeah man, we realized, we reached a point where we realized that man if we're going to get respect for our music, we're going to have to organize ourselves, because nobody's going to do it for us." You know? And that's when they started the AACM.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation. I'm so glad we had the opportunity. I want to thank you for your time and your — how well you speak about your music and everything that goes with it.

SA: I apologize for going on and on sometimes. You know. But as you can see I probably need to publish my books because as you can see I have a lot to say about it, I've got deep feelings about it. It's been basically a love affair. And I'll tell you another funny story before we go — I know we've got a time element. But you know when my mother first came to me and said she wanted me to take music lessons I was against it. You know? I was about seven, eight, something like that. And I didn't want to take music lessons. I didn't want to take piano lessons. And she said, "Why not?" I said, "Because the music is for girls." And she said, "Why would you say that?" I said, "Because all the musicians I see, like in church, they were my aunts and my cousins, but they were all girls." She said, "No, the best musicians in the world are men." And I was like, "Where are they? I ain't never seen none." So one day I was out in the yard playing and my sister came, my older sister came and said, "Mama says come in right now. Come, quick, come." And so she grabbed me and drug me in the living room, and she said, my mom said, "Look." There's a TV on you know, there's Louis Armstrong. Louis Armstrong man, with his trumpet in one hand, a hankie in the other hand. And he's clean, he's got a tuxedo on. She said, "He's the best in the world. There you go. He's the best." I said, "Oh, really?" So that changed my thinking. And then of course then I wanted a trumpet. So anyway that's part of my metamorphosis.

MR: Terrific. I've had a couple — I didn't know the word but now I do — epiphanies myself like that.

SA: Epiphany. Yeah. Yeah. And I don't know how she knew it but she knew, back then in the '50s, she said, "He's the best musician in the whole world." You know? And now over a

hundred years after his birth, or fifty or so years after his death, and pretty much everybody agrees yup, he's the guy. Louis — nobody — like Miles said one time, he said, "There's nothing we can play that Louis hasn't played already." I'm like wow.

MR: Those Hot 5 and Hot 7 records were recorded like a hundred years ago.

SA: Yeah. Well see that's why, Monk that's why we know that this thing is — the mind, it's divinely revealed. It's not really from us. It's something other-worldly. You know like Art Blakey said, "Music is a gift, you know, it's from the creator to the artist, to the artist in split second timing." And that's something that is unrehearsed, is unplanned. We don't know, was it Sonny Rollins or Coltrane one time, somebody came back stage and showed him some music and said, "What do you think about this?" And he said, "Oh it looks interesting but it's just too difficult, I never could play it." And they told Coltrane, "No, this is your solo on 'Blue Trane.'" He said, "I played that?" Yup. There you go.

MR: Wonderful.

SA: Somebody transcribed the whole thing you know. Anyway thanks so much, I really appreciate it.

MR: All right, thanks for your time, I'll pause our recording and then we'll say our good-byes. Appreciate it.

SA: Absolutely. Thank you.